RABBENU AVRAHAM BEN HARAMBAM ON THE PARASHAH

Very Good, Even When We Cannot See Why

Rabbenu Avraham on Parashat Bereshit

Series: Rabbenu Avraham ben HaRambam on the Parashah: ideas from Rabbenu Avraham's commentary on the Torah (which survives on Bereshit and Shemot), taught each week at the Monday HaMaspik LeOvdei HaShem shiur.

Source: Taught at the HaMaspik shiur of Rosh Hodesh Heshvan 5787 (week of Lekh Lekha), HaMaspik 10.1.

Topic: The new weekly feature, and two ideas on Bereshit: why the Torah adds **טוב מאד**, and why the soul is given by **ויפח**, breathing.

A New Weekly Feature — Rabbenu Avraham on the Parashah

Rabbenu Avraham wrote a **commentary on the Torah**, probably on all five books, but only **Bereshit and Shemot** survive. It is not well known: it was **found only in the last hundred years or so**, and the Hebrew edition of Bereshit and Shemot was brought out by **Solomon David Sassoon** (father-in-law of Rabbi Avraham Gabbai of Ohel David in London).

The plan: through the weeks of Bereshit and Shemot (until Pesah), spend about **five minutes each week**, at the start or end of the Monday HaMaspik shiur, on an idea from his commentary. The **Feldheim** edition of HaMaspik includes selected extracts (*likkutim*) at the back, which serve as the baseline. Flicking through, the Rabbi noticed that many of the ideas tie in closely with HaMaspik, and that Rabbenu Avraham quotes not only his father but often his **grandfather, Rav Maimon**.

Although this week is already Lekh Lekha, we begin with **two short ideas on Bereshit**.

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1. Why "טוב מאד"?

וירא אלהים את כל אשר עשה, והנה טוב מאד; ויהי ערב ויהי בקר יום הששי. (Bereshit 1:31)

The question: כי טוב, "כי טוב" אחר שאמר השם יתעלה בפרטי הבריאה. Each day already said *ki tov*. Why repeat **טוב** at the end, and add **מאד**?

His answer: מפני מציאות האדם המשיג ענייני העולם. It is human nature to try to understand the world around us.

- **Some things we can see the benefit of immediately:** the sun, the moon, the heavens and the earth; most species of animals and plants.
- **Some are beyond us: וקצתם נשגב מן האדם אופן הכוונה במציאותם והתועלת בהם.** *(The Rabbi: why do we need millions upon millions of stars and galaxies? To show Hashem's glory, perhaps, but it is hard to say.)*
- **Some even seem better uncreated: ולא עוד, אלא אפשר שיעלה על הדעת במקצתם שמוטב שלא נבראו — כמציאות העקרב והנחש... והארי והדב... והתמסח**: the scorpion, the snake, the lion, the

bear, the **crocodile**.

ואין ראוי לאדם שיסמוך בטוב בריאתו יתעלה על הבנתו ועל מה שיגיע אליו שכלו, אלא ידע כי לשכלו ולדעתו גבול אשר יגיע אליו.

We cannot rely on our own intellect to decide what was worth creating. **Our understanding has a limit.** But because God is perfect, **everything He creates is "very good", whether we understand it or not.** That is what the verse says.

אילו ידעתיו הייתיו: *If I knew Him, I would be Him."* Often attributed to Rav Saadiah; the Rabbi thinks it is actually **Rav Yosef Albo, in the Ikkarim**.

David HaMelekh says the same:

מה רבו מעשיך ה', כלם בחכמה עשית (Tehillim 104). Do I always understand them? No. But I know they are all **with wisdom**.

פליאה דעת ממני, נשגבה לא אוכל לה (Tehillim 139). Some knowledge is too lofty for me.

והראוי לאדם להסתכל במה שנסתפקו הקדמונים בתועלתו ושנעלם מהם: look at things whose benefit earlier generations doubted and which we now understand.

The Rabbi's example: the appendix. As far as he knows, we still don't know what it is for; that's why it's called an *appendix*. But many things in the body and in nature were once a mystery and are now understood. Just as then, so now: **every part of nature has a purpose. It is טוב מאד.** *Simple ideas, but beautiful.*

2. Why "ויפח": He *breathed*?

ויפח באפיו נשמת חיים, ויהי האדם לנפש חיה. (Bereshit 2:7)

(This verse opens Chapter 10 of HaMaspik.) As we learn in the Moreh: everything is **homer** (matter) and **surah** (form). Hashem made Adam **עפר מן האדמה**, the homer, and gave him a **surah**: intellect, consciousness, the mind, what we call the **neshamah**. **Why describe the giving of the form as *blowing*?**

כדי לקרב אל הבנתנו יושר השכל ודקות אותה צורה שכלית, שהרוחות וכדומה נראה יותר זך מן הגשמים האחרים שאנו מכירים.

To convey **how subtle the form is**. Of all our senses, the most subtle is **breath and smell**. Hence the Hakhamim's play on **כל הנשמה תהלל יה**: read it as **כל הנשימה**, *for every single breath* we should praise Hashem. The soul and the breath go together. By contrast, the Rambam famously writes that **touch is the most shameful of the senses**. **Smell is the sense most associated with the neshamah**, so the Torah uses **ויפח** for implanting the surah.

Summary

טוב מאד: everything Hashem made is very good, even where we cannot see why. Our understanding has limits, and what earlier generations could not explain we often understand now.

ויפח: breath, the subtlest sense, conveys the subtlety of the soul, the surah that makes the human being truly alive.

Coming Up

A short idea from **Rabbenu Avraham on the parashah** each week through Bereshit and Shemot, at the Monday HaMaspik shiur. Next: **Parashat Vayera**.

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